The cosmic perspective reminds us that in space, where there is no air, a flag will not wave—an indication that perhaps flag-waving and space exploration do not mix.

The cosmic perspective not only embraces our genetic kinship with all life on Earth but also values our chemical kinship with any yet-to-be discovered life in the universe, as well as our atomic kinship with the universe itself.

At least once a week, if not once a day, we might each ponder what cosmic truths lie undiscovered before us, perhaps awaiting the arrival of a clever thinker, an ingenious experiment, or an innovative space mission to reveal them. We might further ponder how those discoveries may one day transform life on Earth.

Absent such curiosity, we are no different from the provincial farmer who expresses no need to venture beyond the county line, because his forty acres meet all his needs. Yet if all our predecessors had felt that way, the farmer would instead be a cave dweller, chasing down his dinner with a stick and a rock.

During our brief stay on planet Earth, we owe ourselves and our descendants the opportunity to explore—in part because it's fun to do. But there's a far nobler reason. The day our knowledge of the cosmos ceases to expand, we risk regressing to the childish view that the universe figuratively and literally revolves around us. In that bleak world, arms-bearing, resource-hungry people and nations would be prone to act on their "low contracted prejudices." And that would be the last gasp of human enlightenment—until the rise of a visionary new culture that could once again embrace, rather than fear, the cosmic perspective.

† James Ferguson, *Astronomy Explained Upon Sir Isaac Newton's Principles*, *And Made Easy To Those Who Have Not Studied Mathematics* (London, 1757).

†† *Passport to the Universe* was written by Ann Druyan and Steven Soter, who are also the co-authors of the 2014 Fox miniseries *Cosmos: A SpaceTime Odyssey*, hosted by this author. They also teamed up with Carl Sagan on the original 1980 PBS miniseries *Cosmos: A Personal Voyage*.

††† Boolean algebra is a branch of mathematics that addresses values of true or false in its variables, commonly represented by 0 and 1, and is foundational to the world of computing. Named for the eighteenth-century English mathematician George Boole.